Documentation of the MARIPOLDATAbase

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How the data were acquired

The data was obtained through participant and ethnographic observation as well as document analysis at the Intergovernmental Conferences (IGC) of the negotiations for a new legally binding instrument for the conservation and sustainable use of marine Biodiversity Beyond National Jurisdiction (BBNJ) under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS). We took systematic field notes during the second and third two-weeks IGC sessions at the United Nations' New York Headquarters. Regarding the first IGC, which the research team did not attend, we watched the proceedings via the UN webcast and took systematic field notes. During plenaries, working group sessions, and side events, we took systematic field notes based on a matrix, in which we entered observations on contextual factors, such as the delegation of the speaker, the section of the draft being addressed, and a description of the statement's content. The notes are close to transcripts of the statements.

Experimental design, materials, and methods

The data was acquired through the following steps: 1. We took systematic field notes through ethnographic fieldwork during the second, third, and fifth two-week IGC sessions at the United Nations' New York Headquarters. Regarding the first and the fourth IGC, which the research team did not attend in-person, we took systematic fieldnotes using the same methodology based on online participation and digital ethnography. This data was supplemented with notes from side events, as well as all draft texts, and participant lists.

Chatham House rules

In informal negotiation settings (negotiation_setting = “informal informals” / “dialogue/webinar/briefing“ / “informal dialogues”), this database and its use follow the Chatham House Rules.

The Chatham House Rule reads:

> *‘When a meeting, or part thereof, is held under the Chatham House Rule, participants are free to use the information received, but neither the identity nor the affiliation of the speaker(s), nor that of any other participant, may be revealed.’*[1]

To follow this rule systematically, we anonymized the speaking actor in informal settings. Yet this was done in a systematic way so that each anonymized actor received a number which remained the same throughout the database. In detail this means that in informal settings every information in the “actor”, “alliance” and “obo” column was replaced with, depending on the type of actor, “anonymized_state_NUMBER”, “anonymized_igo_NUMBER” etc. In this way the identity of the speaking actor is concealed but the user can follow a specific anonymized actor throughout the database with the same number. To ensure the consistent anonymization of actors throughout the database, this systematic, numeric anonymization procedure was also applied to observations in informal negotiation settings in the text columns “observation”, “comment_obs_original” and

[1] https://www.chathamhouse.org/about-us/chatham-house-rule

“comment_obs_gpt4_corrected” in which all country names were replaced with their respective anonymized version (“anonymized_state_NUMBER”).
However due to the size and complexity of the database, it was not possible to absolutely ensure, that all information on the affiliation of the speaker is anonymized in all columns. Therefore, users of the MARIPOLDATA*base* are obliged to apply the Chatham House Rule and not use or spread this information.

Data cleaning

To clean and structure this large number of raw data files, we developed a code in R (the programming language) that merged all data, sorted it in chronological order, and performed several cleaning and data manipulation steps.[2] These included detecting and correcting many typing errors (made during the data collection) in several columns, which made it possible to effectively filter and browse the data afterwards. For example, the values in the ‘package’ column were streamlined to 1–5 or 9 (general), which allows users to filter the data by package element. The code also cleaned typing errors in the ‘actor’ column (e.g. it found and corrected more than 100 misspellings of the word ‘facilitator’). In a next step, variables were added to the dataset to widen and facilitate analysis options for researchers. For example, the ‘time_difference’ variable (i.e. the number of seconds that each statement lasted) was computed and added. Given that not every row is equal to one statement, whenever statements were recorded over several rows or two researchers took an observation at the same time, the ‘double’ variable is a binary indication of the double rows. Hence, by filtering this variable, a researcher can easily create a dataset where one row equals one statement. The data manipulation code also filled out empty cells in a number of columns with the last recorded value in order to complement the data at times when the note-taking researcher could not keep up with filling out contextual information.
The R code is provided for transparency and explanation. To run the code, the user would require access to the raw files which are not public.

[2] The code can be accessed under https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase and under https://doi.org/10.11587/0XXZ0V in the AUSSDA Dataverse.

Data description:

Variable Name	Value format & values	Explanation, source & methodology	Data cleaning & code
running_id	Numeric	A running id to uniquely identify each row from 1 to 43341	
AUSSDA archive version	2.0 (2024-10-02)	AUSSDA archive version	
digital object identifier	doi:10.11587/0XXZ0V	digital object identifier	
type_obs	Numeric (1-5. Labelled in the following type_label variable as follows: 1 = intervention; 2 = interruption; 3 = opening statement; 4 = other statement or verbal act; 5 = other activity or non-verbal action).	This variable contains the type of the observation in a numeric format.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/type_obs.R

type_label	Character (Labels of previous type_obs variable: 1 = intervention; 2 = interruption; 3 = opening statement; 4 = other statement or verbal act; 5 = other activity or non-verbal action)	This variable contains the label of the numerical types in the aforementioned type_obs variable.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/type_obs.R
actor	Character (State, IO, NGO, other actor name)	This variable displays the actor that is speaking, acting, or being observed. It contains the name of the state, IO, NGO, or UN body. In some cases, other actors or an observation of numerous actors by the researcher. In informal settings, actors are anonymized according to Chatham House rules[3] In many cases a State speaks on behalf of an alliance, this is stated in the column "obo".	Cleaning,correcting of names, anonymization of persons (not published), and informal settings https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/actors.R https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/anonymization.R
actor_type	Character ("UN Body", "State", "Scientific Institute", "IGO", "UN Agency", "NGO", "UN Env. Treaty", "other", and "business")	This column categorizes the aforementioned actor into types of actors. This variable is automatically generated and added to the dataset subsequently to the collection.	Categorization is done according to the rules written in the following file: https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/actor_type.R

[3] https://www.chathamhouse.org/about-us/chatham-house-rule

actor_type2	Character ("Secretariat", "IGO", "State", "Scientific Institute", "NGO", "other", "Industry")	This second categorization of the actor type distinguishes the actors into overarching categories. This variable is automatically generated and added to the dataset subsequently to the collection.	Categorization is done according to the rules written in the following file: https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/actor_type.R
alliance	Character (African Group; AOSIS, Landlocked; Least Developed; G77/China; CARICOM; CLAM; Non UNCLOS Party; [removed for anonymity])	Most individual states formed part of an alliance during the BBNJ negotiations. Alliances existed to different degrees of coordination. For the purpose of this database an alliance was recorded as soon as one state spoke on behalf of two or more states which coordinated a position on at least one provision. This means that while some alliances were official, tightly organized groups, other alliances may have been ad-hoc or loosely organized. This variable shows what alliance the State is part of, where applicable (as some states were not part of a formal alliance).	This variable is automatically generated. When states are members to various alliances, this variable attributes the most specific alliance (with least members) to them. Many states are part of the G77+China but also part of smaller alliances (i.e. African Group). https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/alliances.R

obo	Character	The beforementioned alliances normally had designated states that spoke on behalf of ("obo") the whole alliance. This variable indicates obo which alliance the state at hand spoke. Where a state spoke not on behalf of any alliance, the actor's name is displayed here.	This variable is added computationally. Initially, one state often spoke obo an alliance during the whole IGC, but many alliances divided this task by package items later on. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/obo.R
un_group	Character (African Group; Asia-Pacific; Western European and Others; Latin American)	Each UN state is divided into a regional group in the UN general assembly: https://www.un.org/dgacm/en/content/regional-groups These UN groups did not play a specific role in the BBNJ negotiations. Note that this categorization does not imply that any form of coordination took place within the UN groups.	This variable is automatically generated and adds this categorization of regional groups to the states in the BBNJ negotiations. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/alliances.R

observation	Character	This variable can contain various types of information: a short description of the statements content, the alliance that a state is speaking on behalf of, who the actor is speaking to or an observation of what happens in the room. It is advised to also contextualize this observation with the next column, as in many cases the observation is continued there.	This variable underwent a general computational text (typo) cleaning. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/text.R + Anonymization of Names
comment_obs_original	Character (Gaps in the observation are usually marked as “XX” or “…”)	This variable is a detailed description of the statement. It is the main variable displaying the content of a statement. Depending on author and circumstances, this can range from a listing of main contents up to the exact wording of the statement. This is the original transcript by the researchers.	This variable underwent a general computational text (typo) cleaning. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/text.R Anonymization of Names
comment_obs_gpt4_corrected	Character	This variable is the previous variable comment_obs_original after an automatic chatgpt4 spellcheck. It corrected typos and mistakes to make the texts easier to read.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/chatgpt_spellcheck.R

package	Numeric (1-5;9. Labelled in the following package_label variable as follows: 1 = Marine Genetic Ressources; 2 = Area-based Management; 3 = Environmental Impact Assessments; 4 = Capacity-Building and Transfer of Marine Technology; 5 = Cross-cutting issues; 9 = Other)	This variable contains the package item that is negotiated For an overview of the package elements and their contents please see Tessnow-von Wysocki & Vadrot (2020) or Mendenhall et al. (2019).	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/packages.R
package_label	Character, labels of previous package variable. Labelled as follows: 1 = Marine Genetic Ressources; 2 = Area-based Management; 3 = Environmental Impact Assessments; 4 = Capacity-Building and Transfer of Marine Technology; 5 = Cross-cutting issues; 9 = Other	This variable contains the name of the package as mentioned above.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/packages.R

section_title	Character	This variable contains information on the article or section that is discussed. The numbering of the sections may differ from IGC to IGC as the draft text changed. In some cases multiple articles are referred to or the section title for an observation may also be missing. A link to the draft document under discussion at the respective moment can be found in the 'draft' column. Empty cells mean that the observation does not address any specific section of the draft text or that there is no information on that.	Some streamlining and correction of typos for section titles was undertaken. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/sectiontitle.R
art_title	Character	This variable attributes the title of the previously specified section according to each IGC and the respective draft text. Empty cells mean that the observation does not address any specific section of the draft text or that there is no information on that.	This variable is automatically generated and subsequently added. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/arttitle.R
subsection	Character	In this variable the subsection of the draft text, further dividing the aforementioned section and article title is listed. The subsection normally indicates the individual paragraphs or similar subcategories.	Some streamlining and correction of typos was undertaken. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/sectiontitle.R

issue_detail	Character	This category contains, where applicable, the detailed reference or the issue that is referred to or discussed. In some cases, this is oftentimes similar with the category 'art_title'.	Some streamlining and correction of typos was undertaken. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/text.R
option_detail	Character	This category contains the options in the draft text, if negotiators referred to them. This variable contains information only when negotiators addressed certain options in the draft text or added their preferred amendments or options.	Some streamlining and correction of typos was undertaken. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/text.R
pro_contra	Character with fixed categories ("pro"; "contra; "neutral"; "flexible"; "amend"; or other)	This column displays how the talking actor relates to the issue under discussion. It is advisable to read the previous columns ranging from 'section' to 'pro-contra' together to determine the specific section of the text that was discussed. For a use of the pro_contra column please see the discussion about state positions on the common heritage of humankind principle in Vadrot, Langlet, Tessnow-von Wysocki, 2022.	Some streamlining and correction of typos was undertaken. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/procontra.R

draft	Weblink	This column entails links to the draft texts that were negotiated at the time. It only contains draft texts that were issued before the relating conference. Draft changes within an IGC are not covered. These drafts are a helpful tool to understand the articles and paragraphs under discussion.	Links were added subsequently and computationally. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/links.R
IGC	Character (1-5; 5.2; 5.3, intersessional work, online dialogues)	This column shows the IGC that the statement was made at. IGC 1-5 are the first, second, third, fourth and fifth substantive session respectively of the BBNJ negotiations (https://www.un.org/bbnj/). The resumed fifth session is listed as IGC 5.2. The final adoption session is listed as 5.3. "Intersessional work" refers to virtual intersessional sessions organized by the BBNJ secretariat (https://www.un.org/bbnj/content/Intersessional-work) and "online dialogues" refers to the informal High Seas Dialogues (https://bbnjinformals.org/). Please also refer to Vadrot et al., 2021 and Langlet et al., 2023 for an explanation of these negotiation formats.	

negotiation_format	Character (dialogue/webinar/briefing; informal dialogues; informal informals; plenary; side event; working group; other)	This column describes what format the negotiations were held in (for an overview over different negotiation formats see Bach & Martin, 2023. The negotiation formats mattered for participation issues (https://www.maripoldata.eu/participation-at-bbnj-negotiations-matters/) but informal settings are also important to facilitate the building of trust among negotiators (Vadrot et al., 2021). This variable justifies an important ethical consideration concerning observations that are fully displayed and those that are anonymized corresponding to the informal nature of the negotiation format (Vadrot & Hughes, 2023). Informal (anonymized) negotiation settings are "dialogue/webinar/briefing; informal dialogues; informal informals".	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/negformat.R
date	Date (YYYY-MM-DD)	This column shows the date of the statement taken. The variable is automatically generated the moment a researcher starts typing an observation.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/datetime.R

time	Time (HH:MM:SS)	This column shows the time of the statement. The variable is automatically recorded the moment a researcher starts typing an observation. The date and time of a statement can help to find the respective recording of the statement.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/datetime.R
statement_link	Weblink	This column contains a link to the uploaded pdf of the statement where available. Delegations were given the opportunity to upload their statement in a written manner to the UNDOALOS secretariat which were then made publicly available. Link to the statements of the first session: https://www.un.org/bbnj/statements-first-session	The link was added to the observations based on information on the actor and the date. Where a statement was available with date information this was added to all the statements of the actor of that day. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/links.R

enb	Weblink	Where available this column contains a link to the Earth Negotiations Bulletin (ENB) report of the respective day. The ENB also attended the BBNJ negotiation process and provided daily updates and pictures. ENB reports can be a helpful complementary source to the MARIPOLDATAbase. ENB reporting on BBNJ negotiations: https://enb.iisd.org/negotiations/conservation-and-sustainable-use-marine-biological-diversity-beyond-areas-national	The link was added based on the day of negotiations. This was done subsequently and computationally. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/links.R
webcast	Weblink	Provides a link to the video in the UN webcast of the respective session. Plenary sessions were recorded and can be found at: https://www.un.org/bbnj/content/webcast	The link was added based on the day and time of the statement. This was done subsequently and computationally. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/links.R
unique_time	Date - Time (YYY-MM-DD HH:MM:SS)	This variable combines date and time into one variable and serves to chronologically order the data.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/datetime.R

side_main	Character (side/main/other)	This variable differentiates between 'main event', 'side event' or 'other'. On the role of side events please see Bansard, 2023. Side events were only observed in IGC 2 & 3 when the research team was present in NYC and side events took place. The list of observed side events is not exhaustive and the database only contains notes on the side events that were observed and not of all.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/negformat.R
negotiation_site	Character (Conference room 12, 4, a, c, d, webex)	This column contains, where available, information on the site of negotiations. This is oftentimes the conference room used or in online meeting the digital tool (webex). This variable was often not filled out and remained empty.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/negformat.R
language	Character	This column contains, where specified, the language of the statement. If the column is empty, most statements were in English language.	

double	Binary (1/0)	This column indicates whether rows belong to the same statement or whether a statement was recorded by two researchers simultanously. 1 = means this row is part of another statement or double. 0 = means that this row equals one statement. This variable helps to create a dataset that contains one row for each one statement. Per default, the database contains all observations.	Double is coded to "1" when one of the following rules applied: the row is one of many observations from one statement (e.g. the id_combined equals a prior id_combined) or the same statement (e.g. same actor, same time) was already recorded by another author. https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/double.R
time_difference	Numeric	This variable is the time in seconds that each statement lasted. A missing value means that the observation was at the end of a session and there was not following statements. For these cases no time difference could be calculated.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/double.R
routine_mood_formality	Character (binary: usual/unusual)	This variable highlights moments when the researcher indicated to observe an "unsual" moment. This was coded by subjective perception. This variable was often not filled out and remained empty.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/mood.R

statement_scientific_binary	Character (“yes”/ “no”)	This category binarily describes whether the statement is scientific / related to scientific arguing. The assessment if the issue is scientific was done by the researcher at site. This column was not consequently filled due to negotiation circumstances, and thus not all statements relating to science are accordingly marked. This variable is an automatized reduction of the next variable ‘issue_scientific_qual’.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/scientific.R
statement_scientific_qual	Character	This variable complements the previous binary variable and describes how the statement is scientific or what it is related to in detail.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/scientific.R
sentiment_afinn	Numeric	The language in negotiations matters (Georgiadou, Angelopoulos, and Drake 2020). Sentiment analysis is a method to computationally evaluate large bodies of text. For this variable, we calculated the sentiment score for each statement using the Afinn dictionary. The Afinn dictionary is a list of English terms rated between -5 (negative) and +5 (positive) (Nielsen, 2011). For empty cells no sentiment could be calculated due to the brevity of the statement or because too many words in the statement could not be attributed to a sentiment. Please note that the sentiment analysis used the comment_obs_original text and thus not the corrected version.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/sentiment.R

sentiment_constr	Numeric	This variable shows the sentiment score for each statement using a latent semantic scaling method (Watanabe, 2021, 2023). For this score, the researchers themselves produced a "constructiveness" scale, rating words specific to the negotiation context from "unconstructive" to "constructive". For empty cells no sentiment could be calculated due to the brevity of the statement or because too many words in the statement could not be attributed to a sentiment. Please note that the sentiment analysis used the comment_obs_original text and thus not the corrected version.	https://github.com/ArneLanglet/MARIPOLDATAbase/blob/main/sentiment.R
id_combined	Character	This column combines the author with a running id_number that distinguishes each statement.	

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